

# DECODED EXPLAINED

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6th August, 2026

# NATO Enters a New Strategic Era of Transformation

## *NATO enters a new strategic era of transformation*

For the first time since the creation of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) in 1949, Washington is asking Europe not merely to spend more on defence but also to assume primary responsibility for its own security. This marks a fundamental shift in the transatlantic compact and signals the emergence of a new phase in the Alliance's evolution. The question is no longer whether NATO will endure, but how it is adapting to a changing strategic landscape.

### **America's shift**

The National Security Strategy of the United States of America (November 2025) maintained NATO as America's principal transatlantic alliance while signalling a significant shift in Washington's expectations of European allies, particularly regarding burden-sharing and collective defence responsibilities. It argued that the era of the U.S. serving as Europe's primary security guarantor was drawing to a close and that prosperous European allies must shoulder greater responsibility for defending their own continent. While endorsing NATO's commitment to increase defence spending to 5% of GDP as the new benchmark for burden sharing, the strategy envisaged the U.S. remaining the Alliance's strategic enabler, nuclear guarantor and political convener rather than its sole military backbone. The objective is a stronger, more self-reliant Europe that allows Washington to devote greater strategic attention to the Indo-Pacific.

This rebalancing is already evident. Following Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022, U.S. troop strength in Europe rose to around 1,00,000 personnel. Since then, Washington has gradually reversed that surge. During 2025-26, it withdrew around 5,000 troops from Germany, cancelled the planned deployment of 4,000 troops to Poland, and reduced Brigade Combat Teams in Europe from four to three, bringing the U.S. military presence in Europe down to approximately 75,000-80,000 troops – close to pre-Ukraine war levels. The 36th NATO Summit in Ankara in July 2026 reinforced this transition. While reaffirming the Alliance's commitment to Article 5, members pledged €70 billion in military assistance for Ukraine in 2026, committed to sustaining comparable support in 2027, endorsed European-led development of long-range



**Advitya Madan**

Commanded 15 Punjab in Lebanon under the United Nations Flag, commanded 27 Sector as DIG in Churachandpur, Manipur, and was Brigadier, Operational Logistics, in HQ Western Command. He is currently an analyst on geopolitics, international and defence affairs

NATO's European shift offers India new strategic and defence opportunities

precision strike capabilities and accelerated efforts to strengthen NATO's defence industrial base. The underlying message was unmistakable: Europe must assume greater responsibility for its conventional defence as the U.S. increasingly prioritises the Indo-Pacific.

Lord Ismay, NATO's first Secretary General, famously described the Alliance's original purpose as "to keep the Russians out, the Americans in, and the Germans down". While that dictum captured the strategic logic of the Cold War, NATO today has entered a distinctly different phase that may be summed up as keeping Russia deterred, America engaged and Europe prepared.

### **NATO's evolution over time**

The Alliance's evolution can be viewed in three phases. NATO 1.0 (1949-1991) relied overwhelmingly on American military and nuclear power to deter Soviet aggression and preserve transatlantic unity. NATO 2.0 (1991-2022) followed the collapse of the Soviet Union, expanding eastwards, incorporating former Warsaw Pact members and undertaking operations in the Balkans and Afghanistan. Yet, this period also witnessed declining European defence expenditure and growing dependence on the U.S. for intelligence, logistics, strategic mobility and high-end military capabilities, making burden sharing an increasingly contentious issue.

The Russian invasion of Ukraine has ushered in NATO's third phase, a more balanced transatlantic partnership in which Europe assumes primary responsibility for conventional defence while the U.S. continues to provide strategic enablers such as nuclear deterrence, intelligence, long-range precision strike capabilities and global power projection. This is less a story of American disengagement than one of strategic redistribution.

The scale of Europe's response was evident at the 2025 Hague Summit, where NATO members committed to increasing core defence spending to at least 3.5% of GDP by 2035, with progress to be reviewed in 2029. Germany has doubled defence expenditure since 2023 and aims to reach the same target by 2029 while rebuilding military capability to deter Russia. Moscow, meanwhile, has reorganised its western military

posture with new headquarters, formations and bases facing NATO.

The more difficult challenge, however, is not spending but replacing the American military ecosystem. Even as European armies become stronger, they continue to depend heavily on the U.S. for intelligence, surveillance, satellite support, command and control systems, strategic airlift, missile defence, long-range precision strike capabilities and, above all, the nuclear umbrella. Washington's reduction of rapid reaction assets, including bombers, fighter aircraft, air-refuelling tankers, warships, aircraft carriers and attack submarines, together with the deferred deployment of Tomahawk cruise missiles to Germany, illustrates the extent of that dependence. Europe's central dilemma is therefore not simply building larger armed forces but developing the integrated capabilities that have long underpinned NATO's effectiveness. As Poland's Foreign Minister recently observed, Europe does not need to match American military power; it simply needs to be stronger than Russia.

### **New Delhi and the rebalance**

For India, NATO's transformation is less about Europe than about the redistribution of American strategic attention. A Europe capable of assuming greater responsibility for its own security would enable Washington to devote more diplomatic attention, military resources and strategic investments to the Indo-Pacific, reinforcing the regional balance amid China's growing assertiveness. At the same time, a more capable Europe could emerge as an important partner for India in defence manufacturing, advanced technologies, artificial intelligence, cybersecurity, semiconductors and space.

New Delhi should therefore view these changes through the prism of strategic opportunity rather than alliance politics. Closer cooperation with both the U.S. and Europe can complement, not compromise, India's long-standing commitment to strategic autonomy. If navigated prudently, NATO's new strategic model can expand India's defence industrial partnerships, accelerate technological modernisation and strengthen its position as a leading power in an increasingly multipolar world.

## **NATO Enters a New Strategic Era of Transformation**

**The North Atlantic Treaty Organisation is a political and military alliance created in the aftermath of World War II by 12 countries from Europe and North America**

**Headquarters: Brussels, Belgium, while the Allied Command Operations headquarters is near Mons, Belgium.**

**It was formed by the signing of the Washington Treaty, which is based on Article 51 of the United Nations Charter, “which reaffirms the right of individual or collective defence.”**

**The principle of collective defence (an attack against one Ally is an attack against all) is enshrined in Article 5 of the North Atlantic Treaty, which commits NATO members to mutual defence.**

**Open door policy (Article 10): All European countries are eligible to join NATO.**

**NATO makes its decisions by consensus. Hence, if a new country wants to join NATO, it must be supported by all other members. Any of its member countries can veto a new member.**

**Funding: Every NATO country contributes to the costs of running the Alliance, based on a cost-share formula derived from Gross National Income.**

**Warsaw pact : It was a collective defence treaty signed in 1955 by Russia and seven other states to counter the US-led NATO. (All these seven states are now members of NATO). It was abolished in 1991.**

**NATO Plus : It is a grouping of NATO and five countries — Australia, New Zealand, Japan, Israel, and South Korea. The group works toward boosting global defence cooperation.**

# NATO Enters a New Strategic Era of Transformation

## NATO Countries

- Portugal - Spain - France - Italy - Slovenia - Croatia - Montenegro - Albania - Greece - Turkey
- North Macedonia(2020)- Bulgaria - Romania - Hungary - Slovakia - Poland
- UK - Luxembourg - Netherlands - Belgium - Germany - Czech Republic
- Lithuania - Latvia - Finland
- Denmark - Finland (2023) - Iceland - Norway - Sweden (2024) (Nordic Countries)
- USA - Canada



Countries Not there : Bosnia - Belarus - Serbia - Ukraine - Moldova - Austria - Switzerland

# NATO Enters a New Strategic Era of Transformation

## NATO's Three Strategic Phases



2025 Hague Summit: NATO members committed to raising core defence spending to at least 3.5% of GDP by 2035.

# NATO Enters a New Strategic Era of Transformation

## QUESTION

GS

Hard

International Relations

Prelims 2025

Consider the following countries:

I. Austria

II. Bulgaria

III. Croatia

IV. Serbia

V. Sweden

VI. North Macedonia

How many of the above are members of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization?

Select an option to attempt

☐ A Only three

☐ B Only four

☐ C Only five

☐ D All the six

# Why Must People Be Poor in a State Rich With Minerals?



BABULAL MARANDI

## Why must people be poor in a state rich with minerals?

JHARKHAND POSSESSES nearly 40 per cent of India's mineral wealth, yet many of its mining districts remain among the country's least developed. For decades, coal, iron ore, bauxite and limestone have fuelled India's economic growth, while the communities living closest to these resources have continued to struggle with poor healthcare, inadequate schools, damaged roads, polluted environments and shrinking livelihood opportunities.

It was this contradiction that prompted the Centre to establish the District Mineral Foundation Trust (DMFT) in 2015. PM Narendra Modi had argued that mining-affected communities bear the greatest social and environmental costs of extraction but receive the least share of its benefits. DMFT sought to correct this imbalance by ensuring that a portion of mining revenues was reinvested in the welfare of those living in mining-affected areas. Unfortunately, that promise remains largely unfulfilled.

I recently travelled through West Singhbhum, including the Saranda mining belt, and witnessed first-hand the widening gap between the district's immense mineral wealth and the condition of its people. West Singhbhum, home to some of India's richest iron ore reserves, should have been a model of inclusive development. Between 2016 and 2026, nearly Rs 3,700 crore accumulated under its DMFT. Such resources could have transformed

**Odisha's mineral resources are less than half of Jharkhand's. Yet in 2025-26, Odisha generated nearly Rs 46,000 crore in mining revenue compared with Jharkhand's Rs 22,000 crore**

Saranda and surrounding mining villages through better hospitals, schools, drinking water systems, roads and livelihood programmes. Instead, what I saw were struggling local markets, shrinking economic activity, unemployed youth and communities asking a simple question: Where has the money gone?

The DMFT Rules require every district to make annual reports, budgets, approved works, project progress, governing council decisions, and beneficiary details publicly available. Yet, across Jharkhand, these disclosures are either missing, outdated or inaccessible. Mining-affected communities, for whom the fund was created, have little means of knowing how thousands of crores collected in their name have actually been spent. In Jamda, once a bustling mining township, local traders spoke of declining incomes. Several mining leases expired years ago. As mines shut down, employment disappeared. The effects spread far beyond mine workers. Transport operators lost business, roadside eateries emptied, shops struggled to survive, and young people increasingly migrated in search of work.

Cross the border into Barbil in neighbouring Odisha, barely 20 km away, and the contrast is striking. The geology is identical. The mineral deposits are the same. What differs is governance. Odisha ensured timely auctions after mining leases expired. Jharkhand hesi-

tated. The consequences are visible in the numbers. Since 2019-20, India has auctioned 434 mineral blocks. Odisha auctioned 45, Chhattisgarh 41, while Jharkhand auctioned only three, despite being the country's richest mineral-bearing state. The production gap is equally revealing. Between 2018-19 and 2024-25, Odisha's iron ore production increased from around 120 million tonnes to nearly 180 million tonnes. Jharkhand's production remained almost unchanged at approximately 23 million tonnes.

Revenue tells an even more compelling story. Odisha's mineral resources are less than half of Jharkhand's. Yet in 2025-26, Odisha generated nearly Rs 46,000 crore in mining revenue compared with Jharkhand's Rs 22,000 crore.

Delayed auctions reduce production. Lower production means lower royalty collections. Lower royalties translate into reduced contributions to DMFT. Mining-affected villages receive fewer resources precisely because the mining economy itself has been allowed to stagnate. The debate around DMFT, therefore, is not merely about financial accounting; it is about restoring trust. Before organising new investment summits or announcing ambitious industrial plans, the state must first demonstrate that it can effectively manage the resources it already possesses.

*The writer is Jharkhand's first Chief Minister and currently the Leader of the Opposition in the Jharkhand Legislative Assembly*

## **Why Must People Be Poor in a State Rich With Minerals?**

### **● The Core Paradox**

- **Jharkhand possesses nearly 40% of India's mineral wealth, yet many of its mining districts remain among the country's least developed; communities living closest to coal, iron ore, bauxite, and limestone deposits continue to struggle with poor healthcare, inadequate schools, damaged roads, and shrinking livelihoods**
- **This contradiction prompted the Centre to establish the District Mineral Foundation Trust in 2015, seeking to ensure a portion of mining revenues was reinvested in the welfare of mining-affected communities, a promise that remains largely unfulfilled**

# Why Must People Be Poor in a State Rich With Minerals?

## ● The Odisha Comparison

- Crossing the border into Barbil in neighbouring Odisha, the contrast is striking, the geology is identical, but governance differs: Odisha ensured timely auctions after mining leases expired, while Jharkhand hesitated
- Since 2019-20, Jharkhand auctioned only three mineral blocks against Odisha's 45 and Chhattisgarh's 41, despite being the country's richest mineral-bearing state; Odisha's mineral resources are less than half of Jharkhand's, yet it generated nearly double Jharkhand's mining revenue in 2025-26

## ● The Vicious Cycle and the Way Forward

- Delayed auctions reduce production, lower production means lower royalty collections, and lower royalties translate into reduced DMFT contributions; mining-affected villages receive fewer resources precisely because the mining economy has been allowed to stagnate
- The debate around DMFT is not merely about financial accounting, it is about restoring trust; before organising new investment summits, the State must first demonstrate it can effectively manage the resources it already possesses

## Why Must People Be Poor in a State Rich With Minerals?

**DMFs are statutory bodies in India established by the state governments by notification.**

They derive their legal status from **Section 9B of the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act, 1957,** as amended on 26 March 2015 as the **Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2015.**

In any district affected by mining-related operations, the **State Government shall, by notification,** establish a trust, as a non-profit body, to be called the DMF.

**The Central Government has notified the rates of contribution payable by miners to the DMFs.**

In the case of all mining leases executed before 12th January, 2015, miners will have to contribute an amount equal to 30% of the royalty payable by them to the DMFs.

If mining leases are granted after 12.01.2015, the rate of contribution would be 10% of the royalty payable.

**Pradhan Mantri Khanij Kshetra Kalyan Yojana (PMKKKY)**

The **Ministry of Mines** launched **PMKKKY in 2015** for the **welfare of areas and people affected by mining-related operations,** using the funds generated by DMFs.

To implement various developmental and welfare projects in mining-affected areas, complementing the existing ongoing schemes of the State and Central Government

# Why SC Expanded Scope of Domestic Cruelty Law to Women in Live-In Relationships

## Why SC expanded scope of domestic cruelty law to women in live-in relationships

Vineet Bhalla

New Delhi, August 4

EXPANDING THE protection against domestic cruelty under criminal law, the Supreme Court has ruled that such protection, ordinarily given to married women under Section 498A of the erstwhile Indian Penal Code (IPC), extends to women in live-in relationships as well, provided the couple shares an "intent to marry".

Since the IPC has now been replaced by the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), the judgment will likely apply to the corresponding BNS provision: Section 85. The judgment, delivered on Monday by a bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and N Kottiswar Singh, recognises that women facing cruelty in domestic settings cannot be denied the protection of criminal law merely because they have not undergone a formal marriage.

### The legal position until now

Section 498A of the IPC penalises a hus-

band or his relatives for subjecting a woman to cruelty. Because the provision explicitly uses the word "husband", its application was traditionally restricted to legally valid marriages.

Over the years, the Supreme Court expanded this definition to cover such men who induced a woman into a marriage that is legally void or voidable — for instance, by hiding a previous subsisting marriage — holding that such men cannot claim that they were not a "husband" to escape prosecution for cruelty.

This was what had transpired in the present case as well. The accused man approached the courts to quash a Section 498A case filed by his partner, arguing that since he was already married to someone else, his relationship with the complainant was not a valid marriage. The Karnataka High Court rejected this argument, ruling that when "a man induces a woman to believe that she is lawfully married to him, and thereafter subjects her to cruelty, [he]

cannot be permitted to evade criminal responsibility on the plea that no valid marriage existed in law." This led him to appeal to the Supreme Court.

### Beyond void marriages

The Supreme Court could have dismissed the appeal by relying on the established precedent regarding void marriages, but the bench took up the broader question of whether a man in a live-in relationship can be prosecuted under Section 498A.

The judgment, written by Justice Karol, adopted a "purposive interpretation" of the law, noting that since the original objective of Section 498A was to deter domestic cruelty, the law must adapt to changing social realities, observing that "cruelty, any which way, does not check at the door, whether the house it enters is that of a married woman or not". The court reasoned that if a woman faces cruelty from her partner, it makes no logical sense to offer her the protection of criminal law if she is

married, but deny it if she is cohabiting before marriage. This distinction, it said, "has no rational nexus with the object of preventing domestic violence and is as such offensive to Article 14 of the Constitution of India", which guarantees the fundamental right to equality.

### Why the DV Act is not enough

During the hearings, both the petitioner and the Union government argued against expanding Section 498A, pointing out that unmarried women are already protected under the Protection of Women from Domestic Violence (DV) Act, 2005, since the Act expressly covers not just married persons but also those "related...through a relationship in the nature of marriage".

The Supreme Court rejected this argument on the basis of the fundamental difference between the two laws. The DV Act, it pointed out, is primarily a piece of civil legislation providing remedies like maintenance and protection orders. The court

said that equating it with Section 498A would be a "misstatement of law" because "the import of civil and criminal law is different" since "[o]ne has almost singularly civil and monetary consequences, whereas the other is backed by the force of criminal deterrence".

### 'Intent to marry' is crucial

To determine which live-in couples get this protection of criminal law, the Supreme Court borrowed the concept of a "relationship in the nature of marriage" from the DV Act. The court clarified that a "relationship in the nature of marriage" is a narrower legal subset of a general "live-in relationship". Relying on a 2013 judgment by it, the court reiterated the features of such a relationship, which include pooling financial resources, sharing domestic arrangements, having a sexual relationship, and holding themselves out to society as being akin to spouses.

Monday's judgment, however, added a caveat for the application of Section 498A:

The couple must, in addition to the above, also have the "intent to marry".

This is because, according to the court, while many relationships "may meet all the requirements to be a 'relationship in the nature of marriage'", the partners might choose never to enter matrimony. When this intent is absent, the court held, the relationship should not be equated with marriage for the purpose of invoking a penal provision and its "long list of adverse consequences".

"Those relationships that are in the nature of marriage and also have the requisite intent to marry are the closest to marriage itself, and it is those relationships that shall be entitled to the protection of [Section 498A]," the court ruled.

The judgment noted that the initial burden of proof to establish this intent will lie on the female partner seeking the law's protection. But it did not lay down specific parameters for how this internal "intent" is to be legally recognised.

## **Why SC Expanded Scope of Domestic Cruelty Law to Women in Live-In Relationships**

**The Supreme Court has expanded the scope of protection against domestic cruelty to include women in live-in relationships under certain conditions.**

**Originally, Section 498A of the Indian Penal Code (IPC) provided protection against cruelty to married women.**

**With the introduction of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), this protection now corresponds to Section 85 of the BNS.**

**The court recognized that women in live-in relationships should also be protected if there is an "intent to marry." : which means it applies to Women in Live - in - Relationship also**

**Where to apply : Judicial Activism in the matter of Gender Justice**

# SC Directs Centre to Frame SOPs to Curb 'Digital Arrest' Scams

## SC directs Centre to frame SOPs to curb 'digital arrest' scams

**The Hindu Bureau**  
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday passed a detailed order directing the Centre, States, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and telecom authorities to prepare standard operating procedures (SOPs) to curb "digital arrest" scams.

The court directed them to operationalise mechanisms to redress grievances of victims, initiate criminal action through zero first information reports (FIRs) against cyber fraudsters, and restore the monetary losses of those defrauded in a time-bound manner.

The court referred to a status report submitted by the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) under the Ministry of Home Affairs, which stated that the complaints received on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal against digital arrests have

**Complaints against digital arrests dipped from 1,23,672 in 2024 to 58,249 in 2025, and stood at 16,377 for the period ending June 30, as per the Centre's report to the court**

sharply reduced from 1,23,672 in 2024 to 58,249 in 2025, and stood at 16,377 for the period ending June 30, 2026.

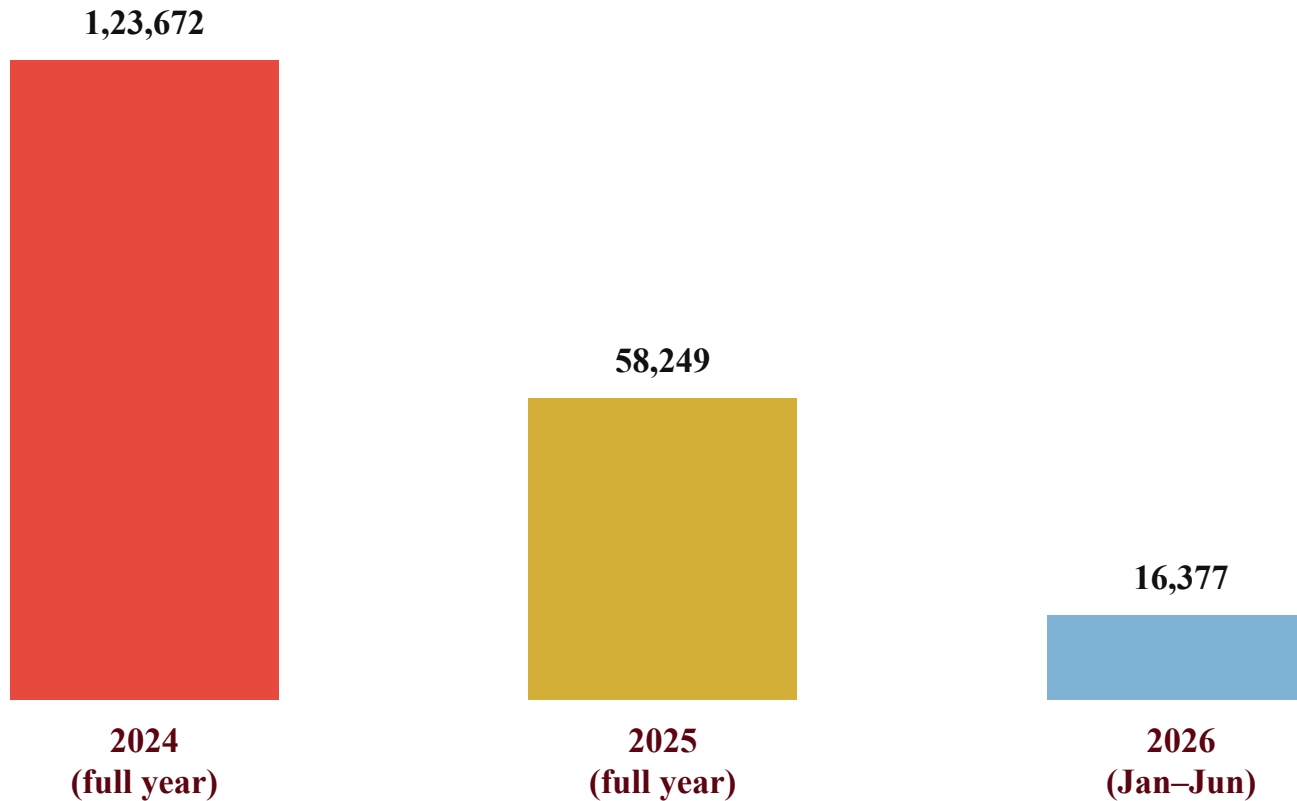
However, the court said though the statistics were "certainly encouraging", it was still essential to monitor the situation.

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## SC Directs Centre to Frame SOPs to Curb 'Digital Arrest' Scams

### Digital Arrest Complaints Are Falling Sharply



Complaints on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal against digital arrests, per the I4C's status report to the Supreme Court.

## SC Directs Centre to Frame SOPs to Curb 'Digital Arrest' Scams

**Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre:** I4C is a national-level coordination centre for addressing cybercrime issues.

It is an initiative by the Ministry of Home Affairs, approved in 2018 and dedicated to the nation in 2020. Its headquarters are in New Delhi. It provides a coordinated and comprehensive framework for law enforcement agencies (LEAs) to tackle cyber crimes.

To coordinate all activities related to the implementation of Mutual Legal Assistance Treaties (MLAT) with other countries related to cyber crimes in consultation with the concerned nodal authority in MHA.

The National Cybercrime Reporting Portal (NCRP), operationalized by the Ministry of Home Affairs, serves as a crucial platform for citizens to report cybercrimes online.

## SC Directs Centre to Frame SOPs to Curb 'Digital Arrest' Scams

- **'Digital Arrest' Scams**

- A form of cyber fraud where scammers impersonate law enforcement or government officials via video or phone calls, falsely claiming the victim is under investigation or 'digital arrest', coercing them into transferring money

- **Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C)**

- An initiative under the Ministry of Home Affairs to provide a framework for law enforcement agencies to deal with cybercrime in a coordinated manner, operating the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal

- **Zero FIR**

- A provision allowing a First Information Report to be filed at any police station regardless of jurisdiction, later transferred to the appropriate station, ensuring victims aren't turned away and enabling prompt action

- **National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal**

- An online platform enabling citizens to report cyber crime complaints, particularly crimes against women and children and other cyber frauds, feeding into I4C's national cybercrime data and coordination system

## Hold Mass Outreach Camps for Doorstep Delivery of Tribal Welfare Schemes: Govt.

### Hold mass outreach camps for doorstep delivery of tribal welfare schemes: Govt

**Nikhil Ghanekar  
& Harikishan Sharma**  
*New Delhi, August 5*

IN A bid to ensure the doorstep delivery of the Centre's tribal welfare schemes, the Ministry of Tribal Affairs (MoTA) has urged all states to conduct public outreach camps in the run-up to Independence Day (August 15).

The MoTA Secretary, it is learnt, has written to all chief secretaries of states directing them to organise 'Jan Sunwai' (public grievance and entitlement camp) at Adi Sewa Kendras between August 13 and 15.

The mass outreach has been proposed through the **Adi Karmayogi Abhiyan**, which was formally launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in September last year to

build up a volunteer-led grassroots tribal leadership of about 2 million people across 1 lakh villages.

As part of the initiative, tribal-dominated villages were encouraged to establish an Adi Sewa Kendra, where local issues could be addressed and resolved, and development roadmaps charted. It is at these Kendras the public outreach camps are slated to be held.

According to government data, 38,509 Kendras have already been established in the country. A further 41,454 remain at the proposal stage.

The Centre has asked district collectors to lead the public outreach, and sought inclusion of the tribal development agency, the local administration, and frontline officers from key departments such as

health, education, rural affairs, forest, among others.

These gatherings have also been utilised by the Centre to widen coverage of two other flagship programmes concerning the welfare of tribal communities, namely the **Dharti Aaba Janjatiya Gram Utkarsh Abhiyan (DAJGUA)** and the **Janjati Adivasi Nyaya Maha Abhiyan (PM-JANMAN)**.

The PM-JANMAN vision is aimed to improve the socio-economic status of particularly vulnerable tribal groups by bridging gaps in health, education, livelihoods, whereas DAJGUA aims for the holistic development of tribal villages.

The upcoming Jan Sunwai outreach initiative will not be the first. Two such events were held earlier — in November 2025 and May 2026.

## **Hold Mass Outreach Camps for Doorstep Delivery of Tribal Welfare Schemes: Govt.**

**Population Size:** India's tribal population is about 10.4 crore, comprising around 8.6% of the total population (Census 2011).

### **EMRS:**

EMRS is a flagship initiative launched by the Ministry of Tribal Affairs (MoTA) in 1998 to provide free, quality residential education to Scheduled Tribe (ST) students from Class VI to XII in remote and tribal-dominated areas.

### **Pradhan Mantri Janjati Adivasi Nyaya Maha Abhiyan (PM JANMAN):**

Focused on PVTGs, aims to improve housing, roads, electricity, education, and livelihood for the most vulnerable tribal groups.

### **Van Dhan Vikas Yojana:**

Aims to enhance tribal income by promoting value addition, processing, and marketing of Minor Forest Produce through SHGs.

### **Pradhan Mantri Adi Adarsh Gram Yojana (PMAAGY):**

Aims to develop infrastructure in tribal majority villages by ensuring convergence of schemes for basic amenities and improved quality of life.

# Cut, Copy: Why Books Are Being Destroyed to Feed AI

## Cut, copy: Why books are being destroyed to feed AI



ANAGHA JAYAKUMAR

IN RECENT weeks, booksellers in Australia and Europe have raised concerns about unusual, bulk purchases of books amid reports that artificial intelligence (AI) companies are acquiring physical copies to train their datasets.

It is the manner of such training, however, that has caused alarm: unsealed documents in a copyright lawsuit against Anthropic revealed that the company was resorting to "destructive scanning", a process in which books are destroyed after their contents are scanned.

*The Guardian* reported recently that Australian booksellers had received requests for books ranging from rare and obscure titles to cheap paperbacks through intermediaries. *Fortune* reported a similar incident involving a Dutch bookseller.

In many cases, intermediaries source books in bulk from sellers before sending them for digitisation, making it difficult for sellers to know who the eventual buyer is.

The reports build on earlier findings about Anthropic's Project Panama. In January, *The Washington Post* reported that the company had bought millions of physical books, removed their bindings and scanned them to build a massive collection of high-quality training data for its models.

The new reports suggest that a practice once visible mainly through court filings and investigative reporting is now becoming visible further up the supply chain, with booksellers noticing unusual demand.

### Why books?

The terms AI and generative AI usually refer to a subset of artificial intelligence called **large language models (LLMs)**. LLMs learn statistical patterns from enormous volumes of content and generate output based on the quality of data fed into them.

While the AI competition in recent times has largely centred on the race for computing power through chips, the push for physical books reflects a growing demand for another critical resource: high-quality training data.

For years, frontier AI companies have relied heavily on text scraped from the public internet. But as AI-generated content

### • UNDER THE SCANNER: THE TWO WAYS TO DIGITISE BOOKS

#### Non-destructive scanning

- Digitises a book without physically altering it, using a V-cribble (see pic) to protect spine.
- An overhead scanner photographs each page while the book remains fully intact.
- Ideal for rare or valuable books that must be preserved.

#### Destructive scanning

- Digitises a book by cutting off the spine and separating the pages.
- Loose sheets are scanned rapidly using automated scanners, producing high-quality images.
- The process is irreversible, making it suitable only for replaceable books that do not need physical preservation.



The 'Scribe' scanner used by Internet Archive. The non-profit digital library says it uses non-destructive digitisation.

### What Indian copyright law says

The legal position under Indian copyright law remains unsettled.

Section 52 of the Copyright Act, 1957, outlines the fair dealing exception, which allows the limited use of protected material without the owner's permission for specific purposes.

The present controversy extends beyond the acquisition of books to what happens to them during digitisation. Once acquired, the books must be converted into machine-readable text before they can be used for training. Many AI companies have turned to destructive book scanning, a process that permanently disassembles physical books for their high-speed digitisation. In the process, they cut the spines of books and feed the loose sheets to the automated document scanners, choosing to recycle or shred the remaining pages. The scanned images are then converted into text using optical character recognition, allowing AI models to ingest them during training.

Destructive scanning has long been used in some mass-digitisation projects because it is faster and produces flat, high-quality images for optical character recognition. However, preservation projects often favour non-destructive scanning to avoid damaging physical books.

The Internet Archive, a digital library best known for preserving web pages and digitising books, has long maintained that it uses non-destructive digitisation, photographing books without dismantling them to preserve the original copy.

In an email reply to *The Indian Express*, Chris Freeland, Director of Library Services at Internet Archive, said the organisation's 2021 explanation of its scanning process "continues to be the best description of its digitisation process today".

In that post, the Internet Archive said its testing of commercial bookscanners, which

feature a vacuum-powered page-turning arm, threatened the integrity of brittle books, rare volumes and other special collections that its library partners wanted digitised.

### The legal questions

The acquisition and digitisation of physical books for AI training also raises a fresh set of copyright questions, even if the books themselves were lawfully purchased.

Anil George Scaria, professor at the National Law School of India University, argues that buying physical books and digitising them for AI training represents a middle ground between negotiating licences with publishers and relying on shadow libraries. "Buying physical copies and getting them digitised for training appears to be the middle path taken by many AI developers now, as many presume that this is fairer to the authors and publishers," he told *The Indian Express*.

The legal position under Indian copyright law remains unsettled. "Whether this is permissible under copyright law may depend on different factors including the question of whether digitisation is done solely for the purpose of AI training or whether the firms had stored it for other purposes also," Scaria said. "If it is done solely for the purpose of training, it should fall under the fair dealing exception under the copyright law," he added, citing the recent *OpenAI vs ANI* decision.

The fair dealing exception, outlined in Section 52 of the Copyright Act of 1957, is a copyright provision allowing the limited use of protected material without the owner's permission for specific purposes such as private study, research, criticism, review, and news reporting.

Scaria made the case for training uses, saying that as non-expressive uses, which are not prohibited under copyright law, they could help advance research and innovation. "Any copyright-related anxieties that copyright owners have could be addressed by making AI developers liable when there is substantial similarities in outputs. This may force AI developers to opt for licence agreements with copyright holders," he said.

Scaria, however, argued that copyright law alone may not resolve the concerns of authors and publishers. "Many copyright holders have anxieties and concerns about the use of their works," he said, adding that "we should also explore solutions outside copyright law", including mandatory labelling of AI-generated content and funds to support authors and artists affected by large-scale AI adoption.

## **Cut, Copy: Why Books Are Being Destroyed to Feed AI**

**An LLM is a type of artificial intelligence (AI) program that can recognize and generate text, among other tasks**

**LLMs are built on machine learning: specifically, a type of neural network called a transformer model, which excels at handling sequences of words and capturing patterns in text.**

**In simpler terms, an LLM is a computer program that has been fed enough examples to be able to recognize and interpret human language or other types of complex data.**

**LLMs use a type of machine learning called deep learning in order to understand how characters, words, and sentences function together.**

**Deep learning involves the probabilistic analysis of unstructured data, which eventually enables the deep learning model to recognize distinctions between pieces of content without human intervention.**

**LLMs are then further trained via tuning: they are fine-tuned or prompt-tuned to the particular task that the programmer wants them to do.**

# Cut, Copy: Why Books Are Being Destroyed to Feed AI

## ● The Emerging Practice

- In recent weeks, booksellers in Australia and Europe have raised concerns about unusual, bulk purchases of books amid reports that AI companies are acquiring physical copies to train their datasets
- It is the manner of such training that has caused alarm; unsealed documents in a copyright lawsuit against Anthropic revealed that the company was resorting to 'destructive scanning', a process in which books are destroyed after their contents are scanned
- In many cases, intermediaries source books in bulk from sellers before sending them for digitisation, making it difficult for sellers to know who the eventual buyer is

## ● Why Books

- The terms AI and generative AI usually refer to a subset of artificial intelligence called large language models, which learn statistical patterns from enormous volumes of content and generate output based on the quality of data fed into them

## Cut, Copy: Why Books Are Being Destroyed to Feed AI

Which of the following statements with regard to Large Language Models (LLMs) used in machine learning is/are correct ?

1. LLMs assign probabilities to the next possible words and then pick the one with the highest probability.
2. LLMs process data through mathematical optimization to minimise prediction errors.
3. LLMs produce unbiased outputs.

Select the answer using the code given below :

[Select an option to attempt](#)

☐ A 1 only

☐ B 1 and 2 only

☐ C 2 and 3 only

☐ D 1, 2 and 3

# A Climate Resilience Pathway Between India and China

## *A climate resilience pathway between India and China*

**T**his year, El Niño delayed the monsoon in India. When the rains arrived, they were intense, with cities such as Mumbai and Surat receiving a month's rainfall in a matter of days. Regions in Assam and Odisha have experienced severe flooding, resulting in loss of life and damage to infrastructure. Similar conditions have recently affected large swathes of China's provinces, particularly Guangxi, Shaanxi and Gansu. Such extreme weather events are becoming increasingly common, threatening economic growth, food security, and public well-being in the two most populous countries.

In both cases, experts attribute these short, high-intensity bursts to climate change which is causing higher atmospheric temperatures and rapidly warming oceans. Mitigating and recovering from these frequent and large-scale events will become increasingly important for China and India to address. Given the scale of the challenge, could climate resilience become an opening for India-China cooperation?

### Similar climate extremes

India and China confront remarkably similar challenges. Rapid urbanisation has replaced wetlands, forests, and permeable surfaces with concrete. Changing weather patterns, combined with outdated drainage systems, poor waste management, rapid urbanisation, and a lack of green spaces, have aggravated waterlogging and flooding. Coastal megacities face the combined risks of extreme precipitation, storm surges, and sea-level rise, while inland cities grapple with heatwaves, droughts, and flash floods occurring in quick succession. These challenges demand scientific collaboration, technological innovation, stronger local governance, and community participation. The costs of inaction include disrupted supply chains, economic losses, declining productivity, and mounting public health risks. This may be the right moment for renewed engagement between India and China. After years of strained ties, bilateral relations are showing tentative and slow signs of improvement.



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Shared climate  
challenges  
create  
opportunities  
for India-China  
cooperation

In April 2026, the visit by a Chinese delegation led by China's Special Envoy for Climate Change to New Delhi suggests that climate cooperation remains a priority. Within the area of climate and clean energy, identifying key issues for engagement is important. Collaboration in areas such as green technology and critical minerals remains challenging due to economic competition and geopolitical tensions. Disaster mitigation and urban resilience could offer a relatively low-risk pathway for rebuilding trust.

### Past engagement, sister city agreements

A mapping of India and China's climate engagement in a recent paper by the Centre for Social and Economic Progress (CSEP) shows that there is precedent for such engagement. Beginning from the early 1990s until 2020, there were several summit-level joint statements, agreements and Memoranda of Understanding (MoUs) calling for practical cooperation on climate change. Topics included climate-induced disasters such as floods, earthquake, droughts and extreme weather events. These MoUs promised facilitation of joint research and development, hydrological, oceanic and seismic data sharing, and exchange of governance practices. During the six Strategic Economic Dialogues, policymakers discussed sustainable urban planning, waste management, sewage treatment, water efficiency and capacity building.

Practical implementation of joint projects in these areas was formally agreed upon in the multiple sister city agreements – Delhi-Beijing, Mumbai-Shanghai, and Chennai-Chongqing. Yet, disruptions in diplomatic engagement resulted in little on-ground action.

China demonstrates the importance of embedding resilience into core urban and rural planning investment decisions. This includes using data-driven approaches to drive policies in transport, housing and drainage systems. India's strength lies in adaptive governance, spearheading community-led strategies for targeted interventions in vulnerable populations.

Successes in India have been seen in early warning systems, heat action plans, cool roofs and nature-based solutions. There has to be engagement between state and non-state actors. Officials from municipal governments can enable knowledge and policy exchanges on urban design such as sponge cities, drainage modernisation and waste management.

Beyond urban issues, rural livelihoods and resilient agricultural practices for food security become salient points for mutual learning. Joint collaboration between planning agencies and academic institutions can improve systems for hydrological modelling and integrating regional and indigenous knowledge into climate adaptation strategies. A critical aspect will be addressing challenges of the melting glacial systems in the shared Himalayan ecosystem. While India and China had agreements on shared water resources, they ceased to function in 2022.

### The finance gap

A major barrier to climate adaptation remains financing, with both countries relying heavily on public funds to carry out their policies. Bridging this gap requires greater private sector participation through tools such as blended finance, municipal bonds, and credit enhancement. However, these are nascent ecosystems, constrained by limited local capacity and regulatory gaps. Evidence-based studies and knowledge exchanges between India and China on these models could provide an innovative avenue for engagement. Such cooperation would not only benefit both countries but also enable them to shape climate resilience norms across the Global South through stronger standards, metrics, and fiscal frameworks.

Climate change impacts transcend national borders, from Europe's heatwaves to Asia's heavy monsoon floods. Greater coordination and cooperation could provide India and China with a pathway for a low-risk, win-win engagement.

*The views expressed are personal*

# A Climate Resilience Pathway Between India and China

## ● Similar Climate Extremes

- This year, El Niño delayed the monsoon in India; when the rains arrived, they were intense, with cities such as Mumbai and Surat receiving a month's rainfall in a matter of days, while regions in Assam and Odisha experienced severe flooding
- Similar conditions have recently affected large swathes of China's provinces, particularly Guangxi, Shaanxi, and Gansu; experts attribute these short, high-intensity bursts to climate change, causing higher atmospheric temperatures and rapidly warming oceans
- India and China confront remarkably similar challenges: rapid urbanisation has replaced wetlands and permeable surfaces with concrete, while outdated drainage systems and poor waste management have aggravated waterlogging and flooding

## ● Past Engagement and Sister City Agreements

- A mapping of India and China's climate engagement by the Centre for Social and Economic Progress shows there is precedent for such engagement; from the early 1990s until 2020, there were several summit-level joint statements and MoUs calling for practical cooperation on climate change
- Practical implementation was formally agreed upon in multiple sister city agreements, Delhi-Beijing, Mumbai-Shanghai, and Chennai-Chongqing, yet disruptions in diplomatic engagement resulted in little on-ground action
- In April 2026, the visit by a Chinese delegation led by China's Special Envoy for Climate Change to New Delhi suggests climate cooperation remains a priority; disaster mitigation and urban resilience could offer a relatively low-risk pathway for rebuilding trust

# A Climate Resilience Pathway Between India and China

## ● What Each Side Brings

- China demonstrates the importance of embedding resilience into core urban and rural planning investment decisions, using data-driven approaches to drive policies in transport, housing, and drainage systems
- India's strength lies in adaptive governance, spearheading community-led strategies for targeted interventions in vulnerable populations, with successes seen in early warning systems, heat action plans, cool roofs, and nature-based solutions
- Beyond urban issues, rural livelihoods and resilient agricultural practices, and addressing the challenges of melting glacial systems in the shared Himalayan ecosystem, are salient points for mutual learning; India and China's agreements on shared water resources ceased to function in 2022

## ● The Finance Gap and the Way Forward

- A major barrier to climate adaptation remains financing, with both countries relying heavily on public funds; bridging this gap requires greater private sector participation through tools such as blended finance, municipal bonds, and credit enhancement
- Evidence-based studies and knowledge exchanges between India and China on these models could provide an innovative avenue for engagement, enabling both to shape climate resilience norms across the Global South

# A Climate Resilience Pathway Between India and China

- **Sponge Cities Concept**

- **An urban planning approach, pioneered in China, using permeable surfaces, green infrastructure, and natural water retention systems to absorb, store, and reuse rainwater, reducing urban flooding and waterlogging**

# The Road Ahead for the Asiatic Lion

## The road ahead for the Asiatic lion

Six decades of conservation have increased the Asiatic lion population from about 100-150 to over 1,000, with nearly half now living outside the protected area; however, the species remains confined to single forested landscape, while habitat fragmentation, disease threats continue to pose major conservation challenges

### FULL CONTEXT

Meena Venkataraman

**T**he only free-ranging population of the Asiatic lion today survives in and around the Gir National Park and Sanctuary. The semi-arid landscape of Gir extends into expansive agricultural fields and traditional grasslands, forming a checkered landscape matrix. Dispersing lions use these habitats as passages, stepping stones, and refuges as they navigate riverbeds and mountainous terrain, eventually establishing territories far from their source population.

Lions today occupy habitats as ecologically distinct as the rugged hills of Girnar, the forests of Mitiyala, the landscapes around Savarkundla-Liliya, and the sandy coastal tracts stretching across Saurashtra to the Bhavnagar coast. What is perhaps most remarkable is that, at their destinations, these lions are accommodated by the local people.

As is evident, the challenge of lion conservation in Gujarat rests not only on protecting Gir, but also on safeguarding the network of habitats and corridors through which lions disperse and establish new territories. Around 50 lions inhabit the coastal habitats of Jafraabad Taluka, linked to the larger lion population through Babarkot. Significantly, the Gujarat Forest Department's 2025 lion population estimation identifies this coastal sector as Satellite IV, one of nine recognised satellite lion populations in the State, while the Gir Management Plan explicitly designates the Babarkot area as a lion movement corridor. Together, these official documents recognise the area as both an important satellite habitat and a crucial landscape linkage for dispersing lions.

**A crucial corridor under pressure**  
It is against this backdrop that a recent proposal to divert approximately 75 hectares of reserved forest for limestone



An Asiatic Lioness with four cubs at Gir Sanctuary on May 12, 2025. VIJAY SONEJI

mining has generated concern. The apprehension is that such a move would run counter to the long-standing legal and management framework established to protect lion habitats and movement corridors. If mining were permitted, habitat disruption could functionally disconnect this coastal subpopulation from the larger forest-linked source population and displace lions from portions of their habitat.

The proposed project would reportedly require the felling of nearly 5,000 mature trees and affect a landscape that local communities themselves do not wish to see mined. Human-lion conflict could also intensify. The larger question is whether the prime habitat of a nationally treasured species, a landscape showcasing one of India's greatest conservation recoveries, should be sacrificed for private profit.

Over the six decades since the declaration of the Gir Sanctuary, the lion population has grown from about 100-150 individuals to a healthy population of over 1,000 today. More admirable, however, is the fact that nearly half of them now reside outside the designated protected area. Lions have, over the years, shown remarkable recovery, expansion and resilience, sustained by a resourceful habitat and a rich prey base.

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

### The unfinished task

This success has been built through a transition from protected-area management to landscape-level conservation, supported by political will, capable administration, sustained funding and the goodwill of local communities. These have been the sturdy pillars of lion conservation.

However, the entire lion population remains confined to a single forested landscape. More puzzling has been the continued resistance to acknowledging the need for a second home for the lions. After years of downplaying the risk of disease in a geographically concentrated population, we received a jolt in 2018 when more than 20 lions succumbed to an outbreak of Canine Distemper Virus (CDV). The forest department responded with a series of immediate measures, but have we effectively applied the lessons learned from previous outbreaks?

Mortality is but a part of a natural demographic cycle. If we are to achieve long-term coexistence in shared spaces, we may even need to accommodate a degree of anthropogenic mortality. Yet the reports of lion deaths associated with babesiosis in May 2026, together with suggestions of possible CDV involvement, are worrying.

If disease exposes the vulnerability of

the population, land-use decisions expose the vulnerability of the landscape that sustains it. These controversies raise a broader question: have the once-strong pillars of the State's conservation legacy begun to weaken? Are cracks emerging in the framework that has sustained lion conservation for decades? Historically, there was little room for negotiation where lions and their habitat were concerned. Indeed, Gir remains an important case study of how protected areas were progressively expanded around the original sanctuary. Hopefully, there will be no shift in the vision underpinning the law, its application, or administrative decision-making.

### THE GIST

▼ Landscape-level conservation, backed by political will, capable administration, sustained funding and local community support, has been the foundation of the Asiatic lion's recovery.

▼ Protecting habitats and movement corridors, addressing disease risks and securing a second home for the species are critical to sustaining India's lion conservation legacy.

### Next chapter of recovery

Given the species' continuing conservation challenges, any ill-advised decision could yet turn the clock back to a far more precarious situation. The International Union for Conservation of Nature Red List tells an encouraging story: the Asiatic lion has moved from Critically Endangered to Endangered. Among the northern lion subpopulations, it is the only stable population exceeding 250 individuals and is therefore of immense global conservation significance. At the same time, the newer Green Status assessments remind us that recovery and restoration are not the same thing.

A species can recover substantially and still remain far from fully restored across its ecological and historical range. Under the Green Status framework, the lion remains largely depleted. While the lion has recovered from the brink, it remains far from fully restored across the landscape it once occupied.

The story of the Asiatic lion is one of sustained recovery achieved through six decades of unwavering conservation effort, and of the responsibility that comes with safeguarding those gains. Our goal is not merely to celebrate this legacy, but to sustain it.

*(Meena Venkataraman, PhD, is a wildlife biologist with over two decades of experience in mammalian ecology, with a particular focus on the Asiatic lion)*

## The Road Ahead for the Asiatic Lion

Lion is the second largest cat species in the world. It is divided into two subspecies: the African lion and the Asiatic lion (Persian or Indian Lion).

The Asiatic Lion (*Panthera leo persica*) is a majestic subspecies of lion and is the only wild population of lions found outside of Africa. It is a keystone species of the dry deciduous forests and open grassy scrublands of the Saurashtra region.

Gir National Park and Wildlife Sanctuary in Gujarat is the only natural habitat of the Asiatic lion in the world.

Due to successful conservation, the population has expanded into the Greater Gir Landscape, covering several districts including Amreli, Bhavnagar, and Somnath.

The Barda Wildlife Sanctuary is being developed as a second home for the natural dispersal of lions to safeguard the species against localized threats like disease.

‘Project Lion’ (launched in 2020) focuses on landscape-based conservation, habitat restoration, and building ecological resilience.

# Thank You